DATA ANALYSIS REPORT

Leaked

India's Examination Paper Crisis, 2004–2026

A statistical analysis of 110 documented exam-paper-leak incidents compiled from public press reporting and official records

July 2026

Source data: paper_leaks.csv · 110 incidents · 24 states & UTs · 2004–2026

Contents

Executive Summary 3

1. Introduction & Methodology 3

2. Key Findings 4

2.1 A Rising Tide: Incidents Over Time 4

2.2 Two Governments, One Recurring Problem 5

2.3 Sector Vulnerability: Where Leaks Concentrate 5

2.4 The Structural Weak Link: State vs. Central Authority 6

2.5 Geographic Hotspots 6

2.6 Repeat Offenders 7

2.7 The Human Cost 7

2.8 Arrests Without Answers: The Accountability Gap 7

2.9 How Solid Is This Record? 8

3. Limitations & Caveats 9

4. Conclusion & Key Takeaways 9

Appendix: Data Dictionary 10

Executive Summary

This report analyzes **110 documented exam-paper-leak incidents** in India between **11 April 2004 and 19 July 2026**, compiled from more than 40 press and official sources. It covers national medical and recruitment entrance exams down to state-level police and clerical recruitment drives, and examines when leaks happen, who they hit, where they concentrate, and what happens afterward.

Five findings anchor the report:

- **A sharp, recent escalation.** 57% of all documented incidents (63 of 110) occurred in 2021–2026 alone, versus a baseline of roughly one to two a year through the 2000s. Whether this reflects more leaks, better detection and reporting, or both, is something this dataset cannot resolve on its own.
- **A structural, state-level problem.** 80% of incidents (88 of 110) trace to state-level exam boards rather than central authorities — even though central exams like NEET draw the most media attention.
- **Concentrated repeat offenders.** A handful of institutions account for a disproportionate share of incidents: Madhya Pradesh's Vyapam board (10 incidents) and CBSE (9) lead the list; NEET-UG alone has faced leak allegations in five separate cycles since 2016.
- **A wide accountability gap.** 1,692 arrests are on record across the incidents that report a figure, but conviction outcomes are disclosed for only 10 of all 110 incidents (9%) — the public record goes quiet after the initial arrests in the overwhelming majority of cases.
- **A real human cost.** 22.5 million-plus aspirants were affected across the 44 incidents that report a figure, led by the 2024 Uttar Pradesh Police Constable exam (4.8 million candidates). Four incidents carry press-reported death tolls, which this report treats with particular care given how contested those figures are in the original sourcing.

The report also documents where the underlying data is thin — most magnitude figures (arrests, convictions, aspirants affected) are reported for well under half of all incidents — and treats every average accordingly, throughout.

1. Introduction & Methodology

Examination-paper leaks have become one of the most persistent governance stories in Indian public life — recurring across state police recruitment drives, medical entrance exams, teacher-eligibility tests, and school boards. This report analyzes a structured compilation of **110 such incidents** spanning 2004 to 2026, built from press reporting, court records, and official statements across more than 40 distinct sources.

1.1 What the data is — and isn't

This is a **press-sourced compilation, not an official government count**. It documents incidents that reached public reporting; leaks that were never publicised — plausibly more common in earlier years, before social media and RTI-driven disclosure were widespread — are not represented. Every figure in this report should be read as a *documented floor*, not a ceiling.

Coverage is also uneven **within** the dataset. Incident-level facts — date, exam name, state, conducting body, leak status — are recorded for all 110 incidents. Magnitude fields are not:

Field	Incidents Reporting	Coverage
Arrests	63 of 110	57.3%
Aspirants affected	44 of 110	40.0%
Convictions	10 of 110	9.1%
Linked deaths	4 of 110	3.6%

Throughout this report, any average or total built on these four fields is explicitly labeled *"where reported,"* not "in general" — treating the 47 incidents with no arrest figure as zero would be a modeling choice, not a fact, and would silently understate every such average.

1.2 A note on political neutrality

The dataset spans both UPA (2004–May 2014) and NDA (May 2014–present) governments at the Centre. Because roughly four in five leaks involve *state-level* exam boards rather than the central government directly, and because documentation capacity (media reach, RTI activism, smartphone circulation) has grown enormously over 22 years independent of which party governs, this report treats era comparisons as **documentation trends, not governance scorecards**. Section 2.2 addresses this directly.

2. Key Findings

2.1 A Rising Tide: Incidents Over Time

Documented incidents were rare and sporadic through the 2000s — one or two a year. The pace quickens from 2011, and from 2021 onward India records double digits almost every year. **2021–2024 alone account for 47.3% of all 110 incidents** in this dataset; 2022 was the single worst year on record, with 15.

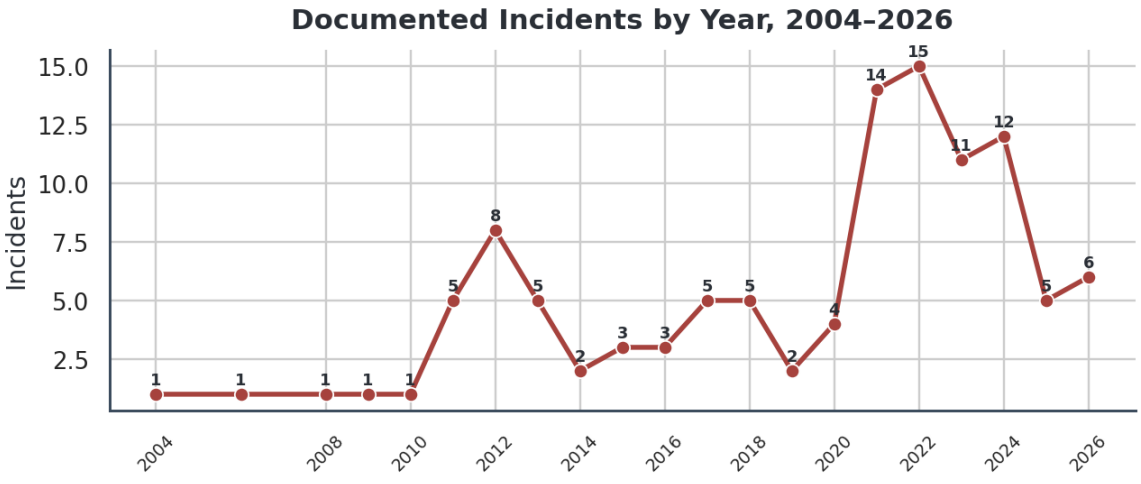


Figure 1. Documented incidents by year, 2004–2026. 2026 is a partial year (through 19 July).

> **READING THIS TREND**
>
> Two very different stories could produce this same chart: paper leaks becoming genuinely more frequent, or leaks becoming far more likely to be **detected and reported** once they happen — through WhatsApp/Telegram circulation, RTI-driven disclosure, and dedicated exam-news outlets that barely existed in 2008. Both are almost certainly true to some degree; this dataset cannot isolate which matters

more.

2.2 Two Governments, One Recurring Problem

The NDA-era rate in this dataset (≈12.2 years of coverage) runs roughly three times the UPA-era rate (≈10.1 years of coverage) — 7.05 incidents per year against 2.38. Total incidents and aspirants affected follow the same pattern.

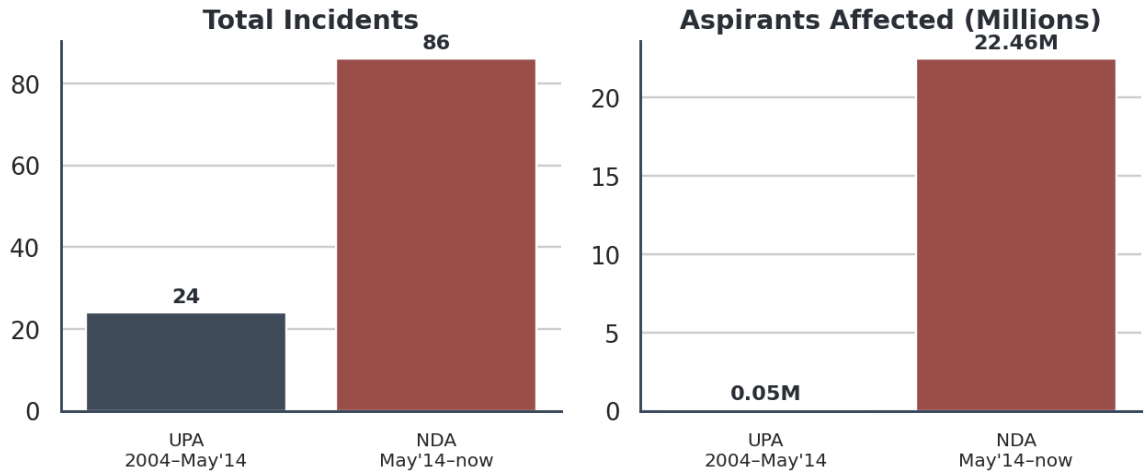


Figure 2. Total incidents and aspirants affected, by governing era.

READ BEFORE DRAWING CONCLUSIONS

This is very unlikely to be a clean governance comparison. Press coverage of paper leaks, RTI-driven disclosure, social media amplification, and the sheer number of aspirants sitting competitive exams have all grown substantially since 2004 — independent of who is in power. Both coalitions include marquee scandals regardless of party: Vyapam began under a **state** government in 2009; NEET-UG 2024 broke under the NDA centre. And since 80% of all leaks are state-board incidents (Section 2.4), most are several steps removed from either central administration. **This chart is best read as a documentation trend, not a causal claim about either coalition's governance.**

2.3 Sector Vulnerability: Where Leaks Concentrate

Once SSC/PCS-style commissions and revenue-officer roles (Patwari, Tehsildar, Lekhpal) are grouped consistently, **Civil Services / Admin leads at 32 incidents (29.1%)**, followed by Medical / Healthcare (20, 18.2%) and Police / Defence (18, 16.4%). These three sectors together account for nearly two-thirds of all incidents — consistent with a simple incentive story: each offers secure, highly competitive government employment or medical seats, exactly the profile that sustains organized “solver” networks willing to pay for advance access.

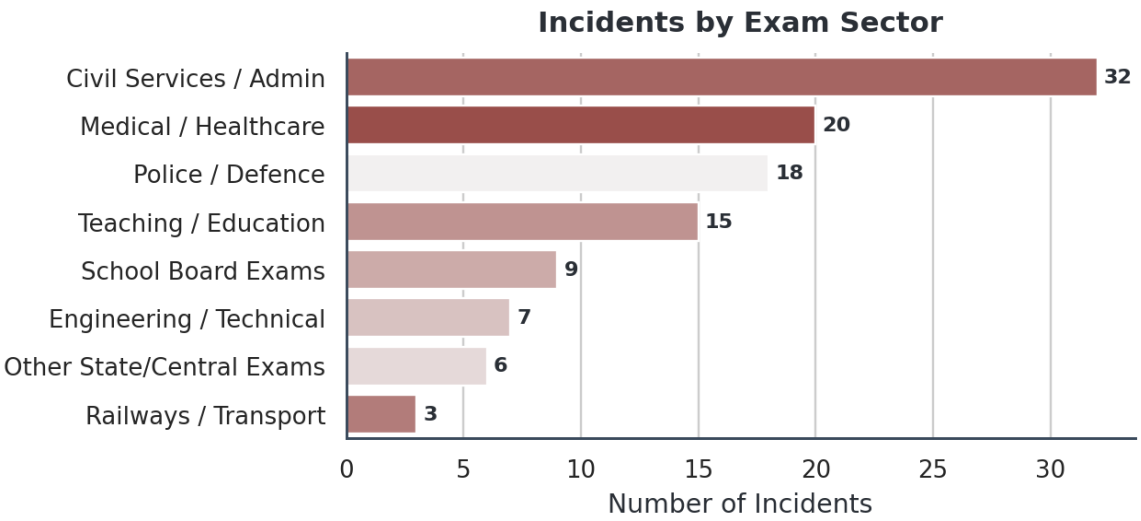


Figure 3. Incidents by exam sector (n = 110).

2.4 The Structural Weak Link: State vs. Central Authority

State-level bodies — state public service commissions, staff-selection boards, and school boards — run **80% of all incidents (88 of 110)**, versus 20% (22 of 110) for central bodies such as CBSE, NTA, SSC, and the Railways. State-run incidents also carry the larger share of human impact: roughly 16.16 million aspirants affected, versus 6.35 million for central exams.

2.5 Geographic Hotspots

"All India" — central, pan-India exams like NEET and SSC that aren't tied to one state — is the single largest area label (16 incidents). Among individual states, **Madhya Pradesh (13) and Uttar Pradesh (12)** lead, with Rajasthan close behind (11). Madhya Pradesh's count is driven heavily by the long-running *Vyapam* scandal (2007–2015), one of India's largest recruitment-fraud cases, spanning dozens of separate exams.

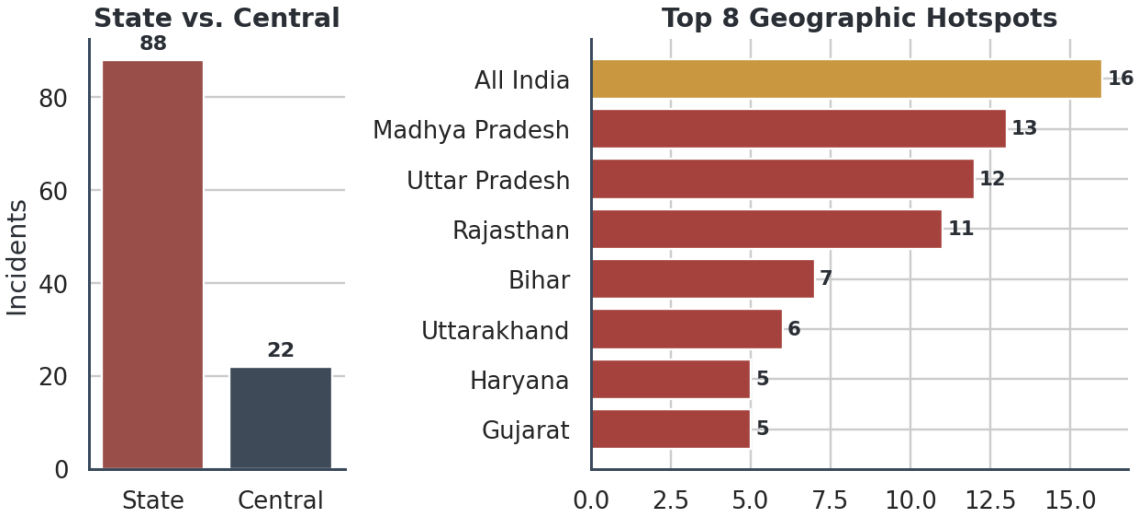


Figure 4. Conducting-body type (left) and the eight most-affected states/UTs (right).

A CAVEAT ON READING GEOGRAPHY

Raw incident counts are not a fair proxy for a state's underlying "leak rate." Larger states run more exams and draw more press coverage; a population- or exam-volume-adjusted ranking would require data this file doesn't contain.

2.6 Repeat Offenders

Some institutions don't leak just once. **Vyapam (Madhya Pradesh's Professional Examination Board) appears in 10 separate incidents on its own** — the scandal that became shorthand in Indian media for large-scale recruitment fraud. **CBSE follows with 9.** Among individual exams, India's flagship medical entrance has now faced leak, allegation, or suspicion in **five separate NEET-UG cycles since 2016** (2016, 2017, 2021, 2024, 2026), plus one NEET-PG scare — confirming medical-entrance exams as the single most recurring target in the dataset.

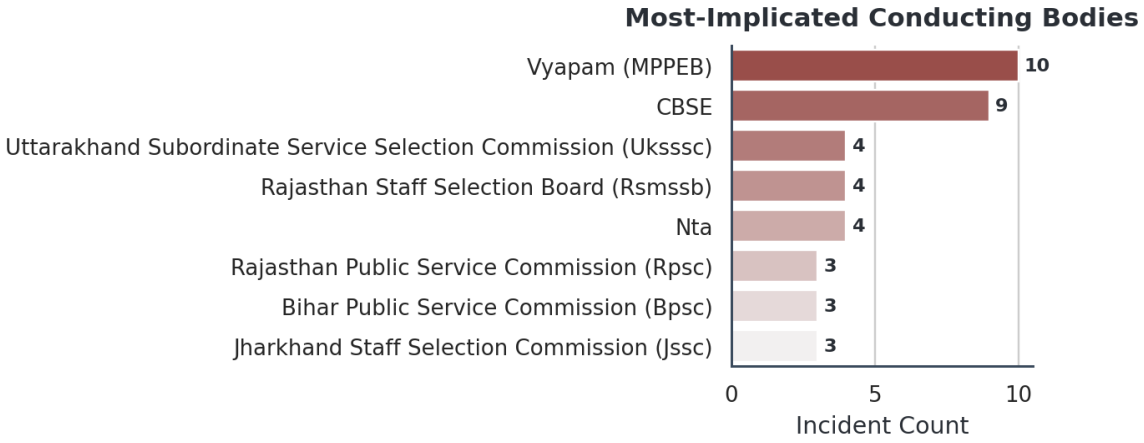


Figure 5. The eight most-implicated exam-conducting bodies, by incident count.

2.7 The Human Cost

Only 44 of the 110 incidents report a concrete number of affected aspirants — but where they do, the scale is enormous. The single largest is the **Uttar Pradesh Police Constable exam (February 2024)**, cancelled after a leak, which had drawn **48 lakh (4.8 million) candidates** for just 60,244 posts. NEET-UG 2024 and 2026 (2.3 million and 2.27 million respectively), the 2021 Uttar Pradesh Teacher Eligibility Test (≈ 2.0 million), and the 2021 Rajasthan Patwari exam (1.56 million) round out the top five — together accounting for more than 12.9 million affected aspirants from just five incidents.

Four incidents in this file carry press-reported death tolls, totaling 41 — mostly aspirant suicides reported around exam cancellations and retest anxiety. **These figures are contested and not officially adjudicated**; the original sourcing for several explicitly flags them as press tallies rather than official causal counts, and one figure (23 deaths linked to the broader Vyapam scandal) mixes suicides, road accidents, and illness across a multi-year period rather than reflecting a single cause. This report treats every such figure with the same caution as its original source.

> **A NOTE ON THIS SECTION**
>
> If exam stress, or anything in this section, is affecting you or someone you know, support is free and confidential through **Tele MANAS**, the Government of India's 24/7 mental health helpline: **14416** or **1-800-891-4416**, available in English and 20 regional languages.

2.8 Arrests Without Answers: The Accountability Gap

1,692 arrests are on record across the 63 incidents that report a figure — but **conviction outcomes are disclosed for only 10 of all 110 incidents (9%)**. Where they are, 114 convictions resulted. For the other 91% of cases, the public record goes quiet after the initial arrests and the headlines move on. A fair per-incident framing is roughly **27 arrests for each of the 63 incidents that report a number** — not an average across all 110, which would silently treat the 47 non-reporting incidents as having zero arrests.

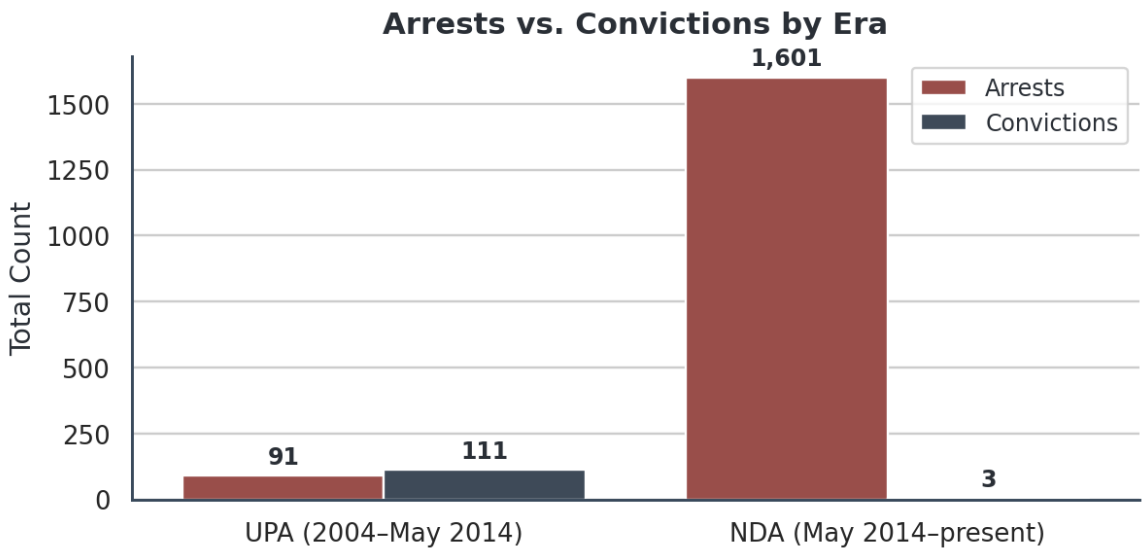


Figure 6. Total arrests and convictions on record, by era.

WHY DOES UPA SHOW MORE CONVICTIONS THAN ARRESTS?

At the era level, UPA logs 91 arrests against 111 convictions — which looks backwards, since convictions normally follow arrests. It isn't an error: **5 of the 7 UPA incidents with conviction data have no arrests figure on file at all**, including three separate Vyapam-linked incidents (2008, 2012, 2013) whose convictions were secured years later as CBI/SIT prosecutions concluded. Those five incidents alone contribute 97 of UPA's 111 convictions (87%) — counted toward the conviction total while contributing zero to the arrests total, since summation skips missing values rather than treating them as zero. A conviction cannot occur without a prior arrest, so real arrests almost certainly happened for these incidents; they simply were never captured as a number in this dataset's sourcing. **Treat era-level arrests and convictions as two independently-sparse counts, not a matched pair.**

Government response follows a consistent pattern: the exam is cancelled or a retest ordered in 58.2% of incidents (64 of 110) — the default response. In a further 34.5% (38 of 110), some enforcement action (arrests, an investigation, or both) occurred but the exam itself was allowed to stand. Where a probe is explicitly named, the Special Investigation Team (SIT, 48 mentions) and the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI, 34) are by far the most common agencies engaged.

2.9 How Solid Is This Record?

Every incident is tagged with a confidence level and a leak status based on how well multiple sources corroborate it. **73.6% are rated high-confidence**, and **80.9% are confirmed** rather than alleged or later denied — a solid evidentiary base overall, though roughly one in four incidents rests on thinner sourcing. Two outlets, Careers360 and The Tribune, together anchor roughly half of all sourced incidents.

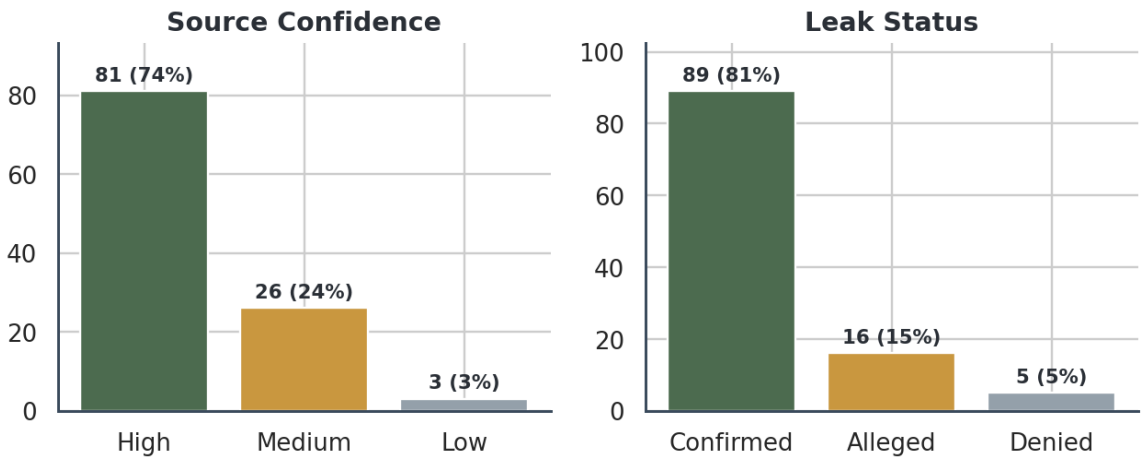


Figure 7. Source confidence (left) and leak status (right) across all 110 incidents.

3. Limitations & Caveats

- **Press-sourced, not an official count.** This dataset documents incidents that reached public reporting. It is a documented floor, not a ceiling, and is almost certainly incomplete for earlier, less-publicised years.
- **Sparse reporting on magnitude.** Arrests (57%), aspirants affected (40%), and especially convictions (9%) and linked deaths (4%) are reported for a minority of incidents. Every average built on these fields in this report is explicitly framed as "where reported."
- **Era comparisons are confounded.** The UPA-to-NDA gap in Section 2.2 likely reflects both a genuine rise in incidents and a rise in detection/reporting capacity; this dataset cannot separate the two.
- **Categorization involves judgment calls.** Sector groupings (Section 2.3) are keyword-based classifications. Coverage is good — the catch-all "other" category covers just 5.5% of incidents — but a handful of exam titles remain genuinely ambiguous.
- **Linked-death figures are contested.** Where reported, several original sources explicitly flag death counts as press tallies rather than officially adjudicated figures. Treat these as the least certain numbers in the report.
- **Arrests and convictions are independently sparse, not a matched pair.** As detailed in Section 2.8, era-level or incident-level comparisons between the two can look contradictory purely because of which incidents happened to report which figure.

4. Conclusion & Key Takeaways

Across 110 documented incidents spanning 2004–2026, India's exam-paper-leak problem has scaled sharply since 2020 — whether from a genuine rise in incidents, a rise in how many get reported, or, most plausibly, both. The affected population is enormous: 22.5 million-plus aspirants across just the 44 incidents that report a figure.

Core thesis

> Paper leaks in India have moved from isolated, opportunistic cheating toward a recurring, structurally concentrated pattern — centered on state-level recruitment boards and a small number of repeat institutions — where visible enforcement activity (arrests, FIRs, probes) coexists with almost no visible

> judicial follow-through. The data supports this pattern clearly; it does not, on its own, support attributing the trend primarily to any single government, sector actor, or cause.

By the numbers

- 63 of 110 incidents (57%) occurred in 2021–2026 alone; 2022 was the peak year (15).
- 80% of incidents originate with state-level exam bodies, not central ones.
- Vyapam (10 incidents) and CBSE (9) are the most-implicated single institutions; NEET-UG has faced leak-related issues in five cycles since 2016.
- Enforcement is front-loaded and largely opaque afterward: arrests average ≈27 per incident where reported, but conviction outcomes are disclosed for only 9% of all 110 incidents.
- India's Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024 was passed directly in response to this pattern, introducing criminal penalties specifically for exam-paper leaks — its deterrent effect is not yet visible in this data; 2026 is currently tracking close to the recent-years pace.

Appendix: Data Dictionary

Field reference for the underlying dataset (paper_leaks.csv / paper_leaks_cleaned.csv). The top block (100%-covered fields) supports incident-level counting with full confidence; the bottom block supports magnitude questions only for the fraction of incidents where a number was ever publicly reported.

Column	Meaning	Coverage
incident_id	Unique identifier, PL-0001 – PL-0110	100%
date / year	Incident date and its year	100%
era	UPA (2004–May 2014) or NDA (May 2014–present)	100%
exam_name	Full exam name as reported	100%
exam_category	Engineered 8-sector rollup	100%
conducting_body	Cleaned, canonical name of the exam authority	100%
body_type	State or Central authority	100%
area / state	Raw location text / cleaned state name	100%
leak_status	Confirmed, Alleged, or Denied	100%
confidence	High / Medium / Low source-verification rating	100%
action_taken	Free text of the official response	100%
arrests	Count of arrests, where reported	57.3%
aspirants_affected	Candidates affected, where reported	40.0%
convictions	Count of convictions, where reported	9.1%
linked_deaths	Press-reported deaths linked to the incident	3.6%

Full source citations for every incident are available in the companion dataset (source_name / source_url columns).